CORE FALSE BELIEF #18 · RULES I LIVE BY

# "I must have everyone's approval."

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## Where it often comes from

The need for approval often begins with parents whose love seemed conditional, frequent criticism, or rejection by peers. A child who learns that keeping others happy keeps them safe may grow into an adult who can't say no, avoids conflict, and feels crushed by any disapproval. Social media can intensify the hunger for likes and praise.

## What Scripture teaches

Paul asked whether he was seeking the approval of people or of God, and concluded that pleasing people could not be his goal. Proverbs warns that the fear of man is a snare, but trusting the Lord brings security. Scripture calls us to work wholeheartedly for the Lord rather than for people. God already approves of His children in Christ. That approval frees us to love and serve others without needing their applause, and to accept that not everyone will be pleased with us.

> *"Am I now seeking the approval of men, or of God? Or am I striving to please men? If I were still trying to please men, I would not be a servant of Christ"* (Galatians 1:10).

## Also see

> "The fear of man is a snare, but whoever trusts in the LORD is set securely on high" (Proverbs 29:25).

> "Whatever you do, work at it with your whole being, for the Lord and not for men" (Colossians 3:23).

> "Instead, we speak as those approved by God to be entrusted with the gospel, not in order to please men but God, who examines our hearts" (1 Thessalonians 2:4).

> "The LORD is on my side; I will not be afraid. What can man do to me?" (Psalm 118:6).

## Common self-statements

- If someone is upset with me, I've failed.
- I can't say no.
- I need people to like me.
- I worry constantly about what others think.
- Criticism crushes me.
- I'll go along to keep the peace.

## Common logical errors

- Mind reading: Assuming people disapprove of me.
- Catastrophizing: Treating someone's disapproval as a disaster.
- Personalization: Taking others' moods as a judgment on me.
- Should statements: Believing I should please everyone.

## Challenging questions

- Whose approval did I need most growing up?
- Is it possible for anyone to please everyone?
- What am I afraid will happen if someone disapproves?

- Whose approval matters most, and do I already have it?
- What have I given up to keep others happy?
- Where could I be honest even if someone is not pleased?

## Truth summary

> I care what people think, and that is human. But I cannot please everyone, and I don't need to. God already accepts me in Christ. His approval frees me to be honest, say no when I need to, and love others without needing their applause.

## Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Self-Esteem, Low
- Fear
- Humility
- Love, By God
- Communication

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Self-Esteem, Low
- Communication

## Listen: Overcoming Anxiety

> Overcoming Anxiety · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 18 minutes

## Songs that speak truth to this belief

**Greater** — MercyMe
God's presence and grace challenge shame and the need to win everyone's approval.

**You Say** — Lauren Daigle
God's loving assessment challenges identity based only on weakness or feelings.

**Voice of Truth** — Casting Crowns
Test accusing or frightening messages against God's truth.

**Blessed Assurance** — Larry Ford and Lillie Knauls with Gaither
This classic hymn celebrates belonging to Christ and resting in His salvation.

*Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"*

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

# My Plan for Replacing "I must have everyone's approval"

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Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

## 1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

*Rate it now so you can see your progress later.*

"I must have everyone's approval." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

## 2 My best question

*The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.*

- ☐ Whose approval did I need growing up?
- ☐ Can anyone please everyone?
- ☐ What am I afraid will happen if someone disapproves?
- ☐ Whose approval matters most?
- ☐ What have I given up to please others?
- ☐ Where could I be honest?

My own question: _____

## 3 My replacement truth

*The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.*

- ☐ I live for God's approval, not man's.
- ☐ The fear of man is a snare.
- ☐ God already accepts me in Christ.
- ☐ No one can please everyone.
- ☐ Disapproval is uncomfortable, not dangerous.
- ☐ I can say no and still be kind.

In my own words: _____

## 4 My Scripture

*The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.*

- ☐ Galatians 1:10
  *"Am I now seeking the approval of men, or of God? Or am I striving to please men? If I were still trying to please men, I would not be a servant of Christ."*
- ☐ Proverbs 29:25
  *"The fear of man is a snare, but whoever trusts in the LORD is set securely on high."*
- ☐ Colossians 3:23
  *"Whatever you do, work at it with your whole being, for the Lord and not for men."*

A verse I found myself: _____

_____

# Practicing the Truth

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## 5 My practice plan

*Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.*

### EVERYONE DOES THESE

- ☐ Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- ☐ Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- ☐ Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- ☐ Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

### PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- ☐ When I sought approval: Each day, write one time you did something mainly for approval, and one time you acted on your own convictions.
- ☐ My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  *For example, Galatians 1:10 becomes: "Mark can write: "I'm not living to please people. I already have God's approval in Christ.""*
- ☐ Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- ☐ Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- ☐ Reading: The "Self-Esteem, Low" topic in Pearls.
- ☐ Listening: The Overcoming Anxiety audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

## 6 My action step this week

*Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.*

*Choose steps you can do safely. If this belief comes with hopelessness or thoughts of ending your life, call or text 988 (the Suicide & Crisis Lifeline), or call 911 in an emergency. You do not have to carry this alone.*

- ☐ Say one kind no. Decline one request this week that you would normally accept to avoid disapproval.
- ☐ Share an honest opinion. Express a different opinion respectfully in a safe setting.
- ☐ Notice the people-pleasing. Each time you change your behavior to win approval, ask, "Whose approval am I seeking?"
- ☐ Rest in God's approval. Read Galatians 1:10 each morning and remind yourself that God already accepts you in Christ.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

## 7 End-of-week check-in

*Bring this page to your next session.*

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "I must have everyone's approval": _____ %  My truth: _____ %

## Daily practice tracker

| Day | Read my card | Said my verse | Used my reminder | A time I acted on my convictions |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| Mon | | | | |
| Tue | | | | |
| Wed | | | | |
| Thu | | | | |
| Fri | | | | |
| Sat | | | | |
| Sun | | | | |

## My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

| Day | Song I listened to | What it told me that challenges the lie |
|---|---|---|
| Mon | | |
| Tue | | |
| Wed | | |
| Thu | | |
| Fri | | |
| Sat | | |
| Sun | | |

## My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~I must have everyone's approval.~~

THE TRUTH

_____

_____

GOD'S WORD

_____

_____

*Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.*

## Prayer

*Lord, I have spent so much energy trying to please everyone. Thank You that I already have Your approval in Christ. Free me from the fear of man, and help me live honestly and lovingly for You. Amen.*

*Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.*